



A variety of gypsum called selenite can form huge crystals, up to 12 m (39 ft) long.



Desert rose

If you could magically turn a rose into rock, it might look like this. However, the object here has nothing to do with magic. If a salty lake dries out in a hot place, it can leave behind lumps of a mineral called gypsum. Grains of sand get mixed into the gypsum, and as the sun bakes it hard, clusters of curved “petals” form — a desert rose. Several desert roses can clump together to form a beautiful bouquet.

Gypsum is a very common and useful mineral. It can be added to water to make plaster, which is turned into panels for use as walls in buildings. Doctors also use plaster to create casts for broken arms and legs.

